

Two men pray.

Luke 18:9-14

One day Jesus told about two men who went to the Temple to pray.

One man was a religious leader who followed God's laws and rules. He was called a Pharisee. The other man was a tax collector.

The Pharisee stood up to pray and said, "God, I thank You that I am not like other men. I am not a thief or a bad person." The Pharisee looked around the Temple and saw a tax collector. "I am not like that sinful tax collector!" People in the Temple must have heard the Pharisee bragging to God about how good he was!

But the tax collector's prayer was very different. He stood quietly by himself. He prayed, "God, have

mercy on me. I am a sinner." The tax collector knew he didn't deserve anything good from God. He knew that he could only receive God's love and forgiveness if God was kind to him.

Jesus said, "God forgave the tax collector but not the Pharisee. The Pharisee was proud. He thought he was better than others were because he followed the rules. But the tax collector was sorry for his sins. He knew only God's love could help him."

Jesus wanted people to know how much we need God's love and forgiveness.